Your first wrestling meet

Mat Rats and Valkyries families
Grindstone Wrestling Club • Westminster Area Recreation Council

Folkstyle quick guide. A pin wins immediately. Otherwise, follow the points and the clock.

The positions

Neutral: neither wrestler has control. Top: the wrestler in control. Bottom: the wrestler working to escape or reverse. Standing up alone does not earn a point.

The individual match score

ACTION	POINTS	WHAT IT MEANS
Takedown	3	Neutral to control of the opponent on the mat
Escape	1	Bottom gets free and returns to neutral
Reversal	2	Bottom takes control directly; no extra escape point
Near fall	2, 3 or 4*	Qualifying back exposure under control: 2 seconds = 2, 3 seconds = 3, 4 seconds = 4
Penalty	Varies	The referee awards points for certain violations

Pin or fall: both shoulders or shoulder blades held to the mat for 2 seconds under standard NFHS folkstyle rules. The match ends, even if the winner was behind.

A score you can follow

ACTION	GREEN	RED
Green takedown	3	0
Red escape	3	1
Red takedown	3	4
Green reversal	5	4

Scores are running totals and carry across periods. Match the referee's wristband to your child's assigned color, not the singlet.

How the match moves

Three periods: first starts neutral; later starts involve a position choice guided by the coach. A whistle may pause action for a restart without any points. Wrestlers stop and follow the referee.

A 15-point lead can end the match by technical fall; the referee lets qualifying near-fall action finish. Otherwise, the higher score wins after regulation. Ties use the event's overtime. Your coach confirms period lengths and overtime.

Scoring basis: NFHS folkstyle, used by USA Wrestling with event modifications. *Near-fall values above are ordinary awards; special situations can add points. Sources and event checklist on back.

At the meet

A match or bout is one contest. A meet contains many matches. A tournament uses brackets or pools. The day can include waiting and more matches after a loss.

Your day in four steps

1 Before you go. Read the team message. Confirm arrival, weigh-in instructions, registration or membership, and the team meeting place.

2 Check in. Find the coach and warm up. Ask how bouts are announced and who covers your child's mat.

3 Be ready. Mat number = where. Bout number = which match, not a start time. "On deck" usually means next; "in the hole" means after that. Recheck assignments and find the coach before reporting.

4 After each match. Check for the next assignment. Tell the coach before leaving, even after a loss.

What to bring

Uniform • wrestling shoes • headgear • water • familiar snacks • warm layer • bag for used clothes. Confirm mouthguard rules, especially with braces. Label gear and ask what the club supplies.

Health comes first

Report pain, illness, or a suspicious rash before contact. Seek medical advice for a possible skin infection. Shower after wrestling, wash and dry used clothing, and do not share towels.

Suspected concussion: stop participation, no return that day, and healthcare clearance before returning. Keep meals and hydration normal. Do not cut weight by restricting food or water or sweating it off.

Parent and spectator conduct

Cheer effort and let your child hear the coach. Respect both wrestlers, officials and volunteers. Let your coach handle scoring concerns. Offer comfort after a tough match.

Please stay in the spectator area unless your child is wrestling or on deck (next to wrestle). Approach matside only if the host allows it. Use designated viewing areas, keep the mat, coaching areas, scoring table and walkways clear, and return to the spectator area after the match.

Our teams and event details

Mat Rats welcomes boys and girls ages 4 to 14. The published first-year Pups clinic, ages 4 to 6, has no competitions. Mat Rats competition teams use the Mid Maryland Wrestling League (MMWL). Valkyries serves girls ages 5 to 14, with optional competitions. Confirm your child's group and event plan.

Coach / contact _____ Team meeting place _____

Arrival / weigh-ins _____ Event updates _____

Sources and help

Club and team details: grindstonewrestling.org Email: grindstonewrestlingmd@gmail.com

USA Wrestling folkstyle rules / USA Wrestling curriculum / NFHS rules / CDC skin care / CDC concussion

Rules checked September 25, 2026. Follow your coach's current event instructions. Freestyle uses different scoring. See the FAQ page for more answers and optional QR links.

New wrestling parent FAQ

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Follow your coach's current event instructions. The published first-year Pups clinic is practice only.

1 When should we arrive?

Check the team message for arrival, weigh-ins and meeting place. Arrive before wrestling starts and find the coach.

2 What if we are late or absent?

Notify your team contact promptly through the usual team channel. Ask what to do next.

3 What should we bring?

Bring uniform, wrestling shoes, headgear, water, snacks and spare clothes. Confirm mouthguard rules, especially with braces, and what the club supplies.

4 Do we need a membership?

Ask whether this event requires USA Wrestling membership or separate registration before buying. Spectator admission does not allow coaching.

5 How are opponents chosen?

Regular Mid Maryland Wrestling League pairings aim to consider age, weight and experience. Tournaments may differ. Ask the coach about pairing concerns before wrestling.

6 What are mat and bout numbers?

Mat means where; bout means which match. On deck usually means next; in the hole usually means after that. Recheck assignments.

7 What if our coach is missing?

Tell a team helper and staging or table staff promptly. Ask for help before the bout.

8 Can we leave after a loss?

Check with the coach before leaving. Your child may have more matches, even after a loss.

9 How long will it take?

Standard folkstyle matches have three periods; your coach confirms timing and overtime. Expect waiting between bouts.

10 How does scoring work?

Takedown 3; escape 1; reversal 2; near fall usually 2/3/4. A pin ends the match. See the handout for details.

11 Why did the referee stop them?

Whistles can signal restarts, safety concerns, penalties or a period ending. A whistle alone does not mean points.

12 Where should I watch?

Stay in spectator areas unless your child is wrestling or next. Approach matside only if the host permits. Return to the spectator area afterward.

13 What if the score looks wrong?

Let your coach handle scoring questions. Respect officials. Report urgent safety concerns to event staff immediately.

14 What if my child is upset?

Offer comfort and tell the coach. Allow time before discussing the match. Praise effort and learning.

15 What about illness or injury?

Report illness, injury or suspicious skin spots before contact; seek medical advice. Suspected concussion: stop sports, no same-day return, healthcare clearance before returning.

16 Should my child cut weight?

No. Keep meals and hydration normal. Do not restrict food or water or sweat off weight. Discuss weight changes with the coach.

Grindstone club information

grindstonewrestling.org

USA Wrestling parent encouragement

TheMat.com — Coaching From the Stands

Optional reading. USA Wrestling article: parent support, not youth match timing. Scoring and safety sources are in the handout and research notes.

Common wrestling penalties

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Penalty points are added to the opponent's score. Cautions and warnings may leave the score unchanged. These are standard NFHS folkstyle rules; ask the coach about any youth or event modifications.

False starts and starting position. Moving before the whistle or lining up incorrectly for a restart. These share two cautions per wrestler per match; each later infraction gives the opponent 1 point.

Stalling. Not making an honest effort to wrestle, such as avoiding action. It has its own sequence: warning, 1 point, 1 point, 2 points, then disqualification. Being behind or getting stuck is not automatically stalling.

Locked hands. From top, illegally locking or overlapping hands or arms around the opponent's body or both legs. Standing, lifting and near-fall exceptions apply; the referee judges the position.

Grabbing gear and other technical violations. Grabbing the singlet or headgear is prohibited. Going or forcing an opponent out to avoid imminent scoring can be the technical violation of fleeing the mat; an ordinary boundary restart is different.

Illegal holds. A prohibited hold or force beyond a joint's normal range, such as a full nelson. A referee can stop a potentially dangerous position before it becomes illegal without awarding a penalty point.

Unnecessary roughness and unsportsmanlike conduct. Examples include unnecessary force, taunting or abusive behavior by a wrestler during the match. A serious act of flagrant misconduct can cause immediate disqualification.

How repeated penalties work

Locked hands, gear-grabbing and other technical violations, illegal holds, unnecessary roughness and wrestler unsportsmanlike conduct during the match share one cumulative sequence: 1 point, 1 point, 2 points, then disqualification (loss of the match). There is no initial warning in this sequence. Switching to a different violation does not restart the count. Stalling and starting cautions are counted separately, as above.

A whistle does not always mean a penalty

A normal out-of-bounds restart, stalemate or safety stop can carry no penalty points. In neutral, the referee distinguishes ordinary boundary action from stalling such as backing out or pushing or pulling an opponent out to avoid wrestling. Watch the referee and scoreboard; let your coach handle questions.

NFHS Rules 5, 7 and 8, including the penalty charts; read with later changes. USA Wrestling folkstyle section 25 uses NFHS rules with modifications. Checked September 26, 2026.

USA Wrestling folkstyle / NFHS rulebook and charts / Current NFHS changes